games. I tried putting bits of foam in my boots but eventually I had to have a complete break from soccer. I couldn't play, I couldn't train. Couldn't even have a kickabout over at the park. That was the longest five weeks of my life and, in a way, I've never got over it. Having to watch soccer instead of playing it still has me climbing up walls.

Ridgeway Rovers was a great time for all of us, not just the players. Our families got involved, whether it was washing uniforms, driving us about, coming on trips or raising funds. That team was together for six years, which meant our families were, too. And you can't spend that amount of time together without becoming pretty close. I remember Micah Hyde's dad, Ken, used to have dreadlocks: him and my dad—short back and sides—would be stood on the touchline together on a Sunday for the Ridgeway game. The parents used to organize dinners and Friday night dances to help raise money to pay for the team. Even though it was Dad who took us for training, my mum probably put in almost as many hours on me and my soccer, despite her job as a hairdresser. She was the only one of the mums who drove, so if there was a minibus run she always ended up with the job. When Dad was out working, Mum would be the one who got me to where I needed to be, when I needed to be there, with the right stuff ready in the right bag.

Looking back, it must have been quite hard for my sisters, with so much of our family time being tied up with my soccer. I've spoken to Lynne about it since and she says she did feel a bit left out by it all. She's three years older than me and had her own friends and just got on with her own life. Even so, when we were at school together Lynne would always stick up for me if there was any trouble. One lunchtime at Chingford High, I remember having an argument with an older boy in the dinner queue. He ended up whacking me out in the playground. It was Lynne who took me home. She made sure I was all right and that the teachers at school knew what had happened. Soccer, though, she didn't really like at all. We've both got our own families now: Lynne and her husband Colin have a girl and a boy, Georgina and Freddie. Even though we don't see that much of each other, I'd say I feel closer to my older sister these days than I ever did when we were young.

It was different with Joanne. I was five when she came along. I can still remember standing in the kitchen at home and my dad coming in and telling me she'd been born and me bursting into tears. I really wanted a brother, of course. But we got on fine: if I wanted her to go in goal in the back garden, she never said no. She just trailed after me all the time: to soccer, the park, the shops, everywhere. Joanne's a hairdresser now, just like Mum, and it's only in the last couple of years, since she started working and I got married, that